Isaac, Jacob, and the Twins

Genesis 25:19–34 · Genesis 27–28 · Genesis 32:22–32

The big idea: God carried his promise through a family of favorites and liars. He chose Jacob before he was born, not because of works but because of him who calls, met him in grace at Bethel, and wrestled him into honesty at the Jabbok.

Before you meet: Read

Genesis 25:19–34 | Genesis 28:10–22 | Genesis 32:22–32

Open (5 minutes)

What is one trait or habit that gets passed down in families, good or bad? Where have you seen it happen?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Two nations are in your womb… the older shall _____ the younger." *(Genesis 25:23)*

"Behold, I am _____ you and will keep you wherever you go." *(Genesis 28:15)*

"Your name shall no longer be called Jacob, but _____, for you have striven with God and with men, and have prevailed." *(Genesis 32:28)*

Discuss

1. Why do you think God chose to carry his promise through such a broken family? What encouragement does that give you? *Genesis 25–50*

2. God chose Jacob before he was born, "not because of works but because of him who calls." Why is that good news for people like Jacob, and like us? *Romans 9:11–14*

3. At Bethel Jacob bargained: "If God will be with me… then the LORD shall be my God." Where are you still bargaining with God instead of trusting him? *Genesis 28:15–21*

4. The last time Jacob was asked his name, he lied. At the Jabbok he told the truth. Why does honesty about who we are matter so much in coming to God? *Genesis 27:19; 32:26–30*

Memory verse

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

Genesis 28:15

Pray

Thank God that his promise never depended on the goodness of Abraham's family, or of yours. Stop bargaining with him, and ask him to make you honest about who you are.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 13

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Genesis 28:10–22 and 32:22–32 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Genesis 37, 39–41, 45, and 50:15–21).

Main points to land

1. God keeps his promises through broken people. Genesis 25–50 is full of favoritism, lies, and jealousy, and the promise to Abraham never fails.
2. God chose Jacob before birth, "not because of works but because of him who calls" (Rom. 9:11). Election rests on God's free grace, without any foresight of faith or good works (WCF 3.5).
3. God met Jacob in grace at Bethel before Jacob repented, and broke him at the Jabbok. The grasper became Israel, limping and blessed (Gen. 28:15; 32:28).

Answer key (Observe)

1. serve
2. with
3. Israel

Questions people will ask

"Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated." Does God hate people?
Set side by side like this, love and hate are words of choosing (compare Luke 14:26). God set his saving love on Jacob and passed Esau by. No one is owed mercy (Rom. 9:14), and Esau was responsible for despising his birthright (Heb. 12:16). Keep the group on the main point: if God chose people for their goodness, he would never have chosen Jacob.

Closing prayer

Father, thank you that you chose Jacob, not because of anything in him, and that you choose sinners like us the same way. Thank you for coming to us before we came to you. Wrestle us into honesty, and teach us to stop grasping and hold on to you. Amen.